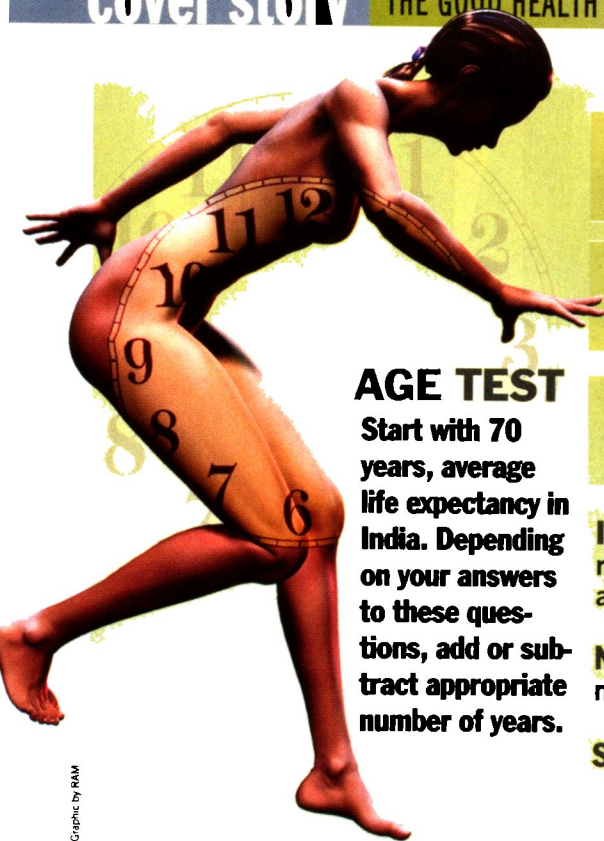




Graphic by RAM

AGE TEST

Start with 70 years, average life expectancy in India. Depending on your answers to these questions, add or subtract appropriate number of years.

An example

Attitude: Are you an optimist? Do you approach life with good humour? Are you able to let go of stressful things? If no, subtract 5 years.

70-5=65

Genes: Do you have at least some family members who have lived past the age of 90? Exceptional longevity runs strongly in families. If yes, then add 10 years.

+10=75

Exercise: Do you set aside at least half an hour, three days a week, to exercise? Muscle-building exercises are particularly important. If no, subtract five years.

-5=70

Interests: Do you do things that challenge your brain, regularly? It's important to take on activities that are novel and complex. If yes, add five years.

+5=75

Nutrition: Do you have a diet which keeps you lean? If no, then subtract seven years.

-7=68

Smoking: Do you smoke? If yes, subtract five years.

-5=63

Total

63 years

chest pain or a stroke. But you may have partly blocked blood vessels in the brain, legs, kidneys or the heart."

With so much evidence that lifestyle is the key to healthy ageing, it might be tempting to ignore the role of genes altogether. That would be a mistake. Swedish scientists tackled the problem in 1998 by looking at the only set of people who share genes but not lifestyle: identical twins separated at birth and reared apart. If genes were most important, you would expect the twins to die at about the same age. In fact, they don't, and the difference convinced the scientists that only about 20 to 30 per cent of how long we live is genetically determined. "The dominant factor is lifestyle," says Dr Nikhil Tandon, professor of endocrinology at AIIMS. "Of course, those who have healthier genes and live healthier lives—really survive for a long time."

Sahay doesn't believe in spending her leisure hours in benign reflections. During her quiet hours, she relaxes with her knitting. Or she reads her favourite book, the *Ramayana*. Or she's on the phone with family and friends (she keeps track of all birthdays and anniversaries). There's more. Every morning, she sets aside time to check out the balance sheets of her ancestral farmland near Bijnor in Uttar Pradesh. In fact, she does it so well that the *kheti* yields a neat profit. Doesn't she get tired? Her eyes light up: "I've always been a cheerful person. Not a complainer."

That's the biggest clue to longevity. The National Institute on Aging in the US reported this year that there's a positive correlation between optimistic disposition and death-age. "Centenarians are invariably strong, flexible characters, emotionally resilient, rooted in family and community," says S.D. Gokhale of Pune, who heads the International Longevity Centre in India. Consider Satyavati Suri, 86, who lives with her daughter's family in Mumbai. "I am surrounded with love and care and I am healthier than people half my age," she says. But there's more. The oldest-old often reflect strong passion for learning. Researchers from the universities of Michigan report that those with long careers live longer and healthier. Why is work and learning associated with better health and greater longevity? "Work requires you to have social contact, use your mind, get some exercise, and all these promote longevity," asserts Gokhale.

If centenarians are navigators who successfully complete the long, perilous voyage—of maladies, mishaps, and conflicts that commonly lead to death—their experiences have much to teach us. And here science converges with common sense. Eat sensibly. Keep walking. Keep knitting. If you can't keep friends, make new ones. Plan so much invigorating work that there's just no time to die. And no regrets when you do. At dusk, surrounded by innumerable portraits of the loved ones she has beaten at the game of life, Sushila Sahay looks forward to yet another day. It's no big deal to be 99.



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